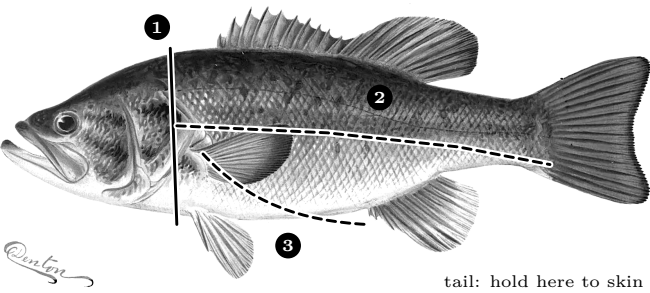


Cooking Largemouth Bass

Micropterus salmoides — in the kitchen

Better than its reputation, if you take it from cold water



The Large-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Much better than anglers say, provided the water was cold. A bass from 50 °F water in April is clean and sweet; the same fish in August can taste of weed and mud.
Texture	Firm and meaty, larger flake than walleye, holds up to grilling and to a heavier sauce.
The mud line	Flavour lives in the dark red lateral strip of muscle just under the skin. Trim it off and most of the complaint goes with it.
Best size	14–17 in. A big old bass is a breeder and coarse eating — put it back.
Yield	About 30% as skinless fillet. A 15 in bass gives two fillets of roughly 4 oz.
Season	Keep bass in spring and autumn; release them in high summer. This is a flavour judgement, not just a conservation one.

Filleting

1. **Cut down behind the gill plate** and the pectoral fin, angling slightly toward the head, until the blade meets the backbone. Do not cut through it.
2. **Turn the blade flat** and run it along the top of the backbone to the tail in one long stroke, letting the spine guide the knife. Leave the fillet attached at the tail so it acts as a handle.
3. **Slice the rib cage out** in a shallow arc, taking as little flesh with it as you can.
4. **Skin it:** fillet skin-side down, grip the tail, run the knife between skin and flesh at a slight downward angle while pulling the skin against the blade.
5. Flip the fish and repeat. Rinse in cold water, pat dry, and get it onto ice.

Bones and what to watch for

Rib cage	The only real bone structure. Step 3 removes it.
The red strip	Run the knife under the dark lateral muscle and lift it off. On a summer bass this is the difference between a good meal and a bad one.
Scales	If you are cooking skin-on, scale it first — largemouth scales are large, tough and will not soften.
Check by feel	Run a finger tip-to-tail before cooking.

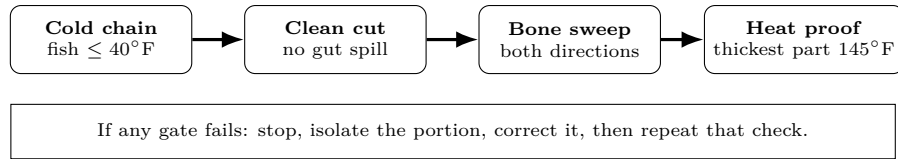
Cooking it

Method	How
Blackened	Bass takes spice better than any other fish here. Coat heavily in paprika, cayenne, thyme, garlic and pepper. Very hot cast iron, butter, two to three minutes a side until the crust is dark. Cook it outside — it smokes.
Grilled in foil	Fillet, butter, lemon, onion, sealed in a foil packet. Twelve minutes over medium coals. Forgiving, and it keeps a firmer fish moist.
Fish tacos	Cube the fillet, dust with cumin and chilli, sear hard and fast. Warm tortillas, cabbage, lime, something creamy. Bass holds its shape in a taco where a bluegill would disintegrate.

Why bass has a bad name

Almost every complaint about eating bass comes from one of three things: a fish taken from warm summer water, the dark lateral strip left on, or a fish carried around on a stringer for hours before cleaning. Fix all three — cold water, trim the strip, ice it immediately — and it is a genuinely good fish. *see the **Handling & Release** sheet*

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For walleye, pike, bass and catfish: **one serving per month** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per week** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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